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The decade marked Indian cinema's most consequential transition since liberalisation. It was a period when Bollywood simultaneously looked outward to the world and inward at its own machinery, when box-office metrics became more corporate, creativity more segmented and popular culture more porous to technology. Cinema was no longer just about films. It became a convergence point for global recognition, digital disruption and celebrity spectacle.

The global moment arrived in 2009. *Slumdog Millionaire*'s sweep at the Academy Awards was less about a single film and more about validation. With eight Oscars, including two for music composer A.R. Rahman and one for sound engineer Resul Pookutty, Indian creative talent stood centre-stage at Hollywood's most exclusionary altar.

Back home, this confidence translated into ambition. The late 2000s saw the formalisation of the 'Rs 100-crore club', a metric that changed how success was measured. Aamir Khan's *3 Idiots* in 2009 did not just smash box-office records; it altered Bollywood's economics and storytelling logic. Intelligent mainstream cinema, anchored in social critique yet wrapped in entertainment, proved commercially invincible. The film's success cemented the star-director-producer triumvirate as a strategic unit and turned revenue into narrative power.

This period also witnessed the consolidation of the superstar economy. Shah Rukh Khan, Aamir Khan and Salman Khan dominated not just screens but entire entertainment ecosystems. Their films, endorsements, television shows and IPL teams fused cinema with brand capitalism. Shah Rukh's expansion into ownership, production and sports entertainment reflected a new idea of stardom, where actors were no longer performers alone but corporate entities.

3 Idiots **didn't just smash box-office records; its runaway success turned the Rs 100-crore club into the industry's definitive benchmark for commercial credibility**





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